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Phils Memories — Once Upon a Time

By PHIL JASNER

One guy packed a lifetime of major league managing into a single day. Another used to take naps in the dugout.

One played pro basketball and big-league baseball in the same years, and got so tired he once tried to give it all up and fly to Israel. Another became an alcoholic.

One used to catch pitchers barehanded, once broke his thumb in a game and slept all night with his hand in a can of ice.

They all played for the Phillies in the misty years between pennants, from 1951 to 1979. Where are they now? What do they recall? And do those memories come laced with laughter or with tears?

These are the Phillies... somewhere in time.

Andy Cohen is 75 now, living in El Paso, Texas, where he spent 17 years coaching at the University of Texas-El Paso, then doubling in the summer with the minor league El Paso Diablos.

"I got a call back in 1960 from John Quinn, then the Phillies general manager," Andy recalled, welcoming the opportunity to reminisce.

"I had worked for John in Boston, and now he was asking if I'd like to coach in Philadelphia. I knew Eddie Sawyer was the manager, and I asked how Eddie felt about it. John said, 'I'm doing the hiring, don't worry about it.'"

"So I came up, happy to be there. We opened in Cincinnati, got beat, and were coming home to play Milwaukee, and Eddie resigned. I got another call from Quinn, this time saying he was appointing me manager for the home opener, for one night.

"One night? I knew why, and I didn't mind. They had hired Gene Mauch, but Gene needed a couple of days to get here. I was in charge until then.

"I'll never forget that night. We beat Milwaukee, 5-4, in 10 innings, one of the biggest thrills I ever had.

"Curt Simmons was my pitcher, and in the third inning he got hit pretty hard. I think Hank Aaron homered, so I put in Ruben Gomez and got three pretty good innings from him, then pinch-hit for Gomez and went with Don Cardwell.

"This is where it gets good... We were in the seventh, a run down, Cardwell was pitching well, and I made up my mind, if the leadoff guy in the inning got on, I was gonna hit for Don.

"But nobody did, I let him bat, and he hit a home run to tie it. He really ripped one, and everybody in the stadium must've thought I really knew what I was doing. Then in the 10th, Bobby Del Greco got on, stole second and scored on a single by Joe Koppe. Hell, I looked pretty smart right about then. I've always wondered if I might've gotten along better with Mauch if I had lost."

Mauch arrived, introduced himself to the staff, then told Cohen and Ken Silvestri they wouldn't be back.

"He was young, full of pep," Cohen recalled. "He was gonna steal games from all the other managers. As he grew older, he matured... mellowed, became a good baseball man."

Andy Cohen says he's retired now, "because it seemed like it was time to do that." He visited once with Dallas Green at a Phillies tryout session in Paris, Texas, but now he's content mostly to watch the games on TV, alone with a lifetime of thoughts.

Let the record show that 1960 was the last year he worked in the major leagues.

Saul Rogovin was the guy with the lo-o-o-ng, slo-o-o-o-w windup, back in '55 and '56. The cynics said Saul used to take occasional naps in the dugout.

"I did, too," he was saying on the phone from New York, where he teaches English at Charles Evans Hughes High, "but not for the reasons everybody thought."



Saul Rogovin demonstrates his knuckleball grip

"It was through certain psychological pressures, a defense mechanism. Those naps were never controlled. It wasn't as if I'd just settle in and nod off.

"It was more like a blackout, lasting a short time. I took medication to help me, but only on the days I was pitching. People thought I didn't care, but that was never the case. And I didn't like the medication, either, because I had bad reactions to it.

"I pitched good ball while I was there. I just wish, someday, they'd invite me to one of their Old Timers games. I'd love to come. Other than that, I'm happy they're in a World Series."

The Phillies got him from Baltimore, something Saul remembers as a good move.

"We were a last-place club in Baltimore," he said, "and I had lost seven, eight games, so

they released me. I felt I could still help somebody, so I sent telegrams to all the big-league teams, and Roy Hamey — then the general manager with the Phillies — was the only one to respond.

"I won five games in '55, seven in '56. A lot of players called me a junkball pitcher, thought I had nothing, but I had pretty good results, a nice, rising fastball. In '55, we needed one win to clinch fourth place, they asked me to pitch, and I beat the Giants in the Polo Grounds.

"But by '57, they had Jack Sanford coming back from the service. Dick Farrell, Jack Meyer, Jim Owens... and those fellas could throw a ball through a wall. My time was up. I was 35, 36 years old, they didn't need me anymore."

He sounds like a sensitive man, who understands the spectrum of emotions that can engulf an athlete.

"I'd like to be at the Series," he said. "When they jump around, celebrate, I know how they feel. And I understand how (Houston's) Jose Cruz felt, after the playoffs, sitting there, staring off into space. I know what was in his mind, too."

"You get so few thrills like that in a lifetime, it's a peak experience. How often does it come along for any one player? The Phillies won, I used to play for the Phillies, I was wishing I could be out there with them."

Gene Conley was here in '59. Eddie Sawyer was his manager, Robin Roberts his roommate.

"People try to tell me it was hard to play in Philly, but I never felt that way," Gene said from Foxboro, Mass., where he owns an industrial packaging supply business.

He had a fascinating career, because he pitched in the majors in the summers, then played forward for the Boston Celtics in the winters.

"I won 12 games by August in '59," Gene said, "and one day I got hit with a pitch, in the opener of a two-night doubleheader, when the ball was a little hard to see."

"I got hit on the hand, broke two bones. But I didn't say much, I went out and finished the game, using ice packs and ice water between innings. Just dazzled 'em... at least that's the way I like to remember it. Then I went to a hospital, had a cast put on."

He says he thoroughly enjoyed his dual careers, but any time anyone asks, they also ask about the time Gene Conley said he was giving it all up to fly to Israel.

"That was in '61, and I was with the Red Sox by then," he said. "I was a tired guy, had played 13 straight seasons, and it was catching up with me."

"I pitched in New York, they made three, four errors behind me. I said if I had won, I thought I had a chance to go to the All-Star Game, but instead I got bombed, took off for four, five days, physically and mentally exhausted. I knew I had to get straightened out, and as I think about it now, can you think of a better place to do that than Jerusalem?"

Lovable, controversial, celebrity-oriented Bo Belinsky was here in '65 and '66, rode the roller coaster for as long as he could, then retreated to the bottom of the bottle.

He's in San Diego now, working for the Padres and running Operation Cork, an alcohol and drug-abuse awareness program.

"I'm an alcoholic," Bo said, "but I've been sober for five years. The program we have, Joan Kroc (wife of Ray Kroc, the Padres owner) is behind it, it's important to her. I ought to be good at it, I tell everybody, 'cause it's supposed to take one to know one."

"I hit the bottom five years ago, had to give up the old ways and start over. I was given a gift... I was given back my life, because I was a dead man, one who was either gonna really die or end up in an asylum."

"A guy in a society that does such things carried the message to me. I was in a rehabilitation ward, a place I had been before, but by now I was probably going insane. For whatever reason, it was finally my time to listen."

Anyway, Bo says he's rooting for the Phillies.

"For a few reasons," he said. "First, my family still lives up in Trenton, N.J. Second, 'cause the Carpenter family was always nice to me. And, third, because of Pete Rose, who helped me get to Cincinnati in '70, the last year I played, when I was just hangin' on. People may have a different view of Pete, but I know him as a kind man."

He came to the Phils from the Angels, and the coast-to-coast move was traumatic.

"I was indoctrinated to the California life by then, to Hollywood, to the glamor," he said.

Continued on Page 81



Cohen



Thomas



Sullivan



Burk